Nagas had also been staying, they were taken to see a PLA officer. According to Sanyal, ‘Some 16 or 17 PLA commanders participated in the marathon meeting that lasted for well over two hours. They learnt about the happenings in Naxalbari at length; they wanted to know how it all began, how many weapons we had and what we planned to do next.’[73]

Over the next few weeks, the four Indian Maoists were introduced to Mao himself and they were then sent for military training. They learnt how use automatic rifles, machine guns, and hand grenades, and to plant mines and make explosive devices. Chinese-Hindi interpreters were at hand and they were also taught ‘Mao Zedong thought’ and how to apply it to Indian conditions. They were also told not to approach the Chinese Embassy in Kathmandu again but to establish a route through other parts of Nepal and Bhutan for what was described as ‘future cooperation’, which would include arms supplies.[74] The Chinese assured them that they would cover all the costs of setting up secret camps along the suggested route.

In mid-December, after spending three months in China, Sanyal and his team were driven back to Kathmandu in a Chinese army vehicle. They then returned to India by bus and, once on the other side of the border, caught a train for New Jalpaiguri near Siliguri in northern West Bengal.

It seemed like a promising beginning for a people’s revolution in India and, throughout 1968, smaller, Naxalbari-type struggles erupted in different parts of India, especially in Srikalulam in Andhra Pradesh, an old revolutionary stronghold. On 22 April 1969, the 100th anniversary of the birth of Vladimir Lenin, the CPI (ML) was formed. The party’s formation was announced nine days later by Sanyal at a massive May Day rally in the Kolkata Maidan. Mazumdar became its first general secretary. India now had its own pro-Chinese Communist party, different from both the CPI and the CPI(M) and much more radical and militant. Radio Beijing beamed more revolutionary bulletins from India and extracts from articles written by Mazumdar.

During the height of its struggle in 1969–70, CPI(ML) attracted a motley crew of supporters ranging from Bengali intellectuals to rural activists, and outright goons drawn from Kolkata’s lumpenproletariat. Hundreds of ‘class enemies’ were ‘annihilated’ by the Naxalites, which meant that they were shot or bludgeoned to death. The victims of ‘the Red Terror’ included landlords, money lenders, policemen, and corrupt local